

INTRODUCTION



‘Forty thousand men are ready to take on the real Tantia Topee and five thousand of his sepoy’s’, was the summary of a letter from Major General G.S.P. Lawrence to the secretary to the Government of India.

This letter would have been otherwise routine fare during the War of 1857, however, this was written on 29 June 1863, four years after the War was over!¹ Such was the panic the name Tatya Tope struck in the hearts of the English, even years after he was allegedly executed by the English themselves. Tatya’s campaigns had become legendary during the war.

Generations later, the legend lives on. The name of Tatya Tope remains in the hearts and minds of the people of India, Central India in particular, even today. In 2007 a newborn baby, in a village near Shivpuri (in Madhya Pradesh), was named after Tatya Tope in honour of the hero.

‘Tatya used to store ammunition here...,’ someone whispered, as the author and his family peered down the dark tunnel leading to the basement of an old house. The place was Yeola, in northern Maharashtra, about thirty-five kilometres from Shirdi. The legend was alive in the family as well. It was this small house, where the author’s father, Prabhakar Tope, spent his childhood years. Tatya Tope, the Tope family’s ancestor*, also spent his childhood in Yeola in a house nearby, before moving to Bithur (near Kanpur) with his family.

Tatya Tope was not just one of the important leaders of the War of 1857; but as this book demonstrates, a central figure. During his times, he was a

*See family tree.

strategist whose electrifying marches very nearly reversed the outcome of the war; and later a legend admired by subsequent generations. Tatya's later campaigns, in 1858 indeed brought him to northern Maharashtra; however, Tatya was never near Yeola to have stored any ammunition in this ancestral home. Family folklore had that, Tatya once visited this house, disguised as a sadhu, several months after he was 'executed' by the English. Then, there were stories of Tatya receiving messages in lotuses and sending messages in chapatis shortly before the war started. While many of these stories were largely myths, buried within these myths were nuggets of information that helped the author unravel a couple of puzzles that had remained unsolved for over 150 years.

The author learnt about the 'Sepoy Mutiny' of 1857 in his history lessons during secondary school. While Tatya Tope's name stood out in history books, Tatya's real role in the war, and the story of 1857, remained muddled in the presentation.

The historiography of 1857, first penned by the victors of the war, presented an obvious Anglo-centric bias. Although challenged in 1908, most subsequent narratives remained largely loyal to the Victorian presentations. There were minor semantic changes, and the role of the civilians was amplified to synchronise with political views; yet, the historiography remained largely revisionist in its outlook. Recent attempts to challenge this biased history, have been attacked as 'rebellious against history', by entrenched academics, who have made a career defending this 'history'.

The author is of the opinion that the real historiography of 1857 remains blurred with these revisionist lenses, and what is required to bring clarity, is not just a 'rebellion', but a 'war' on the 'history' of 1857. The continuation of a 'war' that was first declared over a hundred years ago.

THE WAR ON 'HISTORY'

Vinayak Damodar Savarkar was the first person to challenge the historiography of 1857 when he published *The Indian War of Independence-1857*.²

Writing in 1908, Savarkar was not attempting to be an academic in search of coveted scholarships, or to win accolades and laurels. Neither was he hankering for the label of a great historian nor looking to earn fellowships in England. His goal was simply to liberate India, and the book

was written to inspire Indians to rise against the English. Referring to the Indian nation, Savarkar wrote:

...within her heart, whose treasure is all-forbearing calmness, besides concealed, the terrible power of vengeance, too... Hast thou ever beheld a volcano! Apparently it is clothed with soft green vegetation; but let it once open its jaws, and then all sides will begin to pour forth boiling lava...³

As a later chapter in the book discusses, this volcano erupted on 18 February 1946 and changed India's history forever.

Beyond the inspirational elements of his book, Savarkar viewed 1857 in a completely different context. Considering that he was only twenty-four when he wrote this book, Savarkar showed an extraordinary insight into understanding the potency of the events of 1857. He challenged the premise of 1857 as a 'Sepoy Mutiny', and urged his readers to view the 'real history' of 1857 writing:

...to write a full history of a revolution means necessarily the tracing of all the events of that revolution back to their source – the motive, the innermost desire of those who brought it about. This is the telescope which will show clearly the lights and shadows obscured by the blurred presentation of partial and prejudiced historians. When a beginning is made in this manner, order appears in the apparent chaos of inconsistent facts, crooked lines become straight, and straight lines appear crooked, light appears where darkness is, and darkness spreads over light, what appeared ugly becomes fair, and what looked beautiful is seen to be deformed. And expectedly or unexpectedly, but in a clear form, the Revolution comes into the light of real history.⁴

Savarkar had only scratched the surface when he demonstrated that a significant reassessment of 1857 was required for a more complete understanding of the events of 1857. His job, relative to the historiography of 1857 remains unfinished, thanks to the continuation of 'partial and prejudiced historians' and academics who chose not to further study Savarkar's underlying thesis. Regardless of Savarkar's rigour and objectivity in writing, 1857 is indeed

a very difficult subject, particularly from an Indian perspective. John Kay, a Victorian historian, who wrote three volumes of the 'history' of 1857, commented in his preface about the difficulty of the task, writing, '...truth lies very far below the surface. It is a long and laborious task to exhume it'.⁵ Despite their obvious biases, the task for the Victorian historians, was therefore of exhuming what was buried beneath the surface.

For the Indians, however, history was literally, and figuratively, cremated when India lost the war. What survived and was published as 'history' is highly biased accounts, which were largely rubber stamped by later Indian academics and 'official' historians on the subject. The task today, of finding the truth, therefore, is not simply about exhumation of history, but that of reconstructing it.

History was cremated, because most of the communication between the Indian leaders of the war was destroyed.⁶ So was objectivity. Amongst what has survived, of any communication with any Indian leaders of the war, are over a hundred letters in Urdu written to Tatya Tope. Tatya Tope was a mentor to Nana Saheb Peshwa, who was amongst the main leaders of the War. These previously unpublished letters, mostly written over a three-week period in early 1858 give us an insight into the government of Nana Saheb Peshwa that was established in Bundelkhand in 1857 until the fall of Jhansi and Kalpi in 1858.

In the last chapter of his book, Savarkar underscores the advanced planning that took place prior to the war, and follows up with a question:

Then, why was there a defeat?

Answering his own question, Savarkar opines that:

...the chief reason appears to be this. Though the plan of the destructive part of the Revolution was complete, its creative part was not attractive enough. Nobody was against destroying the English rule, but what about the future?⁷

As the present book argues, India lost the War for reasons far less abstract than Savarkar's conclusions. Considering his motivations in 1908, it is not difficult to see that Savarkar was projecting his personal experiences that

he needed to address, to what happened in 1857. As a twenty-four-year-old revolutionary, Savarkar faced the paradox of destructive versus the creative elements of a revolution, which he attributes to 1857. Savarkar's thrust was to inspire other Indians for an armed revolt against the English. His challenge, as he attempted to inspire people around him, was indeed 'what about the future?' This book demonstrates the existence of both, the 'destructive' and the 'creative' elements of 1857. Therefore, the challenges of 1857, were very different than 1908.

The 125 Urdu letters represent only a small fraction of the communication that was taking place. As a later chapter in this book discusses, Tatya Tope, as the representative for an independent Indian government, demonstrated remarkable ability to manage multiple civil and military functions simultaneously. Savarkar was not privy to this 'creative' side of 1857 when he ascribed India's defeat on that particular point.

Undoubtedly, new source materials such as these provide an important insight into the events of 1857. Yet, a real wealth of information stares us in the face in what is already published. This treasure can be uncovered by simply analysing and assessing the information from another context.

There are a few critical elements essential in understanding the history of any war, more so that of 1857. These include the study of troop movements, their logistics and most importantly, their supply lines. Despite the large body of work that has been published on this subject, one finds precious little information on the aforementioned topics, especially the troop movements. Thousands upon thousands of Indian soldiers marched millions of man-miles in the period, which remains largely ignored. A study of Tatya Tope's movements after June 1858 uncovers a dramatic story that has never been told. *Operation Red Lotus* is an attempt to view the events of the War of 1857 from a vantage point that is vastly different from what has been presented so far.

Most narratives describe the battles based on reports filed by English officers and generals. These narratives have an obvious bias: Indian strengths are exaggerated, defeats are presented as victories and pages upon pages are dedicated to British 'courage and bravery'. However, a study of the troop movements before, and after the battles, often exposes English mendacity in the accounts. The analysis in this book focuses primarily on the movement of the troops and other events, rather than accepting English narratives at face value, to reconstruct the reality of 1857.

A few months before the war started, red lotus flowers mysteriously began to appear in the garrisons where Indian soldiers were stationed. This was followed by a chain of 'chapatis' that were travelling from village to village. Savarkar beautifully expresses the symbolism of the red lotuses that were making the rounds of the garrisons prior to the war, that were carrying an inspirational message.

A Lotus flower! The symbol, the poet-appointed symbol of purity, victory, light! And its colour red, vivid red! ... What a tumult of thoughts must be raging in the mind of every sepoy when he touched the red flower! That courage which it would have been impossible for the eloquence of orators to inspire was imparted in those warlike fellows by the dumb lotus flower and by mute eloquence of its red, red color.⁸

While Savarkar accurately recognised the symbolism of the red lotus, these red lotuses were not mute. They actually carried an important numerical message, and 'spoke back', to their senders. This book attempts to 'hear' what these 'mute' flowers relayed and to solve the 150-year-old puzzle of the red lotuses and the mysterious chapatis. As this book demonstrates, there was a direct link between the red lotuses, the chapatis and the *real* cause of India's defeat.

As the significant events of 18 February 1946 unfolded, Savarkar's primary goal of liberating the country was achieved; however, the history of 1857 remains incomplete. Savarkar declared a war on 'history' when he successfully published his book despite being proscribed by the English in many countries. At the centennial year of Savarkar's groundbreaking book on 1857, the Tope family is attempting to carry forward Savarkar's task when he wrote *The Indian War of Independence-1857* with a focus on Tatya Tope's role in the War.

Many Indian historians have difficulty in understanding the real history of 1857, primarily because they use yardsticks defined by the English. Obviously, these criteria betray an Anglo-centric point of view. By changing the vantage point, the same information yields dramatically different results.

A renowned Indian 'historian' on the subject insisted that 1857 was not a 'war' but 'purely a mutiny of the sepoys', primarily because the existence of a nation was a prerequisite for a 'war'. The Indian nation, in his opinion,

never existed until the twentieth century. The biases in the history of 1857 emerge from a foundation that is built on a fundamentally flawed axiom. The foundation of the Anglo-Indian War of 1857 is rooted in how one views India the country and India the nation.

THE FOREVER NATION

European polity has dominated modern discourse in recent times. Western notions of a nation evolved from their tribal roots, where linguistic and cultural identities eventually defined their political units as nations. Influences of the three Semitic religions during varying periods reinforced this rigidity. These religions derive their own identity from books, each considered as the 'final' word from God, therefore unique and superior to others. Tribal identities, and later religious dogmas eventually emerged as the glue that bound these European tribes. Europe evolved from a large collection of warring tribes to a smaller collection of warring states that had distinct individual identities. This became Europe's definition of a nation-state. Recently there has been an attempt in Europe to reassess the impliability of these attributes. Since the late twentieth century, Europe is making an attempt to politically unite these disparate nations.

Indic polity, however, is in complete contrast to these western experiments in nation building. Western ideas of a nation can therefore, never apply to India. In India's history, not a single major empire ever was limited to one language group or a sectarian association. While hundreds of sects have existed within the framework of Indic thought, one's existence was never considered a threat by others. From Emperor Ashoka to the times of the Marathas and Mughals, empires enlarged and shrunk, but language and sects were never a primary criteria in their identity – neither the Vijayanagar Empire, nor the Marathas. For the English and other European intellectuals, in their own sense of logic, the Indian identity was too nebulous to be considered a nation. The same applied to faiths that have originated in India, the world's 'thought factory'.

Unfortunately, historians like R.C. Majumdar and many others, who viciously refute the existence of the Indian nation during 1857, view India from these European lenses.

The words 'nation' and 'country' are often used interchangeably; however, there is an important distinction between the two. Geographical boundaries only define a *country* as a political unit. The Indian *nation*, however, is defined by a few core attributes, such as traditions, stories that are narrated across generations and the faiths that have originated on its soil.

Unlike many modern nations that came into prominence in the second millennium CE, the political boundaries of ancient nations such as India, or China, spanned across their diverse cultures and languages. The current process of the attempted unification of Europe was, in many ways, already mature in nations such as India and China a few thousand years ago. Whether empires in India shrank or expanded, or their names changed with time, the concept of a common polity, which we describe as a *nation*, was always well recognised, both within and outside.

India as a *nation* has a unique place in world history: it is the *only* nation in the world that has successfully defended the *continuity* of the core attributes that define it. India is the only *living* ancient civilisation in the world. India's continuity in its history, culture and polity is unmatched by many other great nations. Not China, Japan or Egypt. Not Greece or Rome; neither Mesopotamia, Sumeria nor Europe. Not any nation in the Americas, Africa or Southeast Asia.⁹

To be able to successfully defend the nation and its core beliefs, in addition to military prowess, economic freedom and more importantly, political freedom, is a prerequisite.

Despite a few hiccups, India to its credit has had the longest winning streak in its ability to remain both, a free nation and a free country; five thousand years as a nation and nearly four thousand years as a country. This is not to suggest that everything in India is five thousand years old, but that the continuous evolution of ideas, stories, faiths and philosophies from ancient times until today, continued on its own terms, and even thrived, despite the advent of foreign political and religious influences.

As a free country, if one measures the continuity of political freedom, India's winning streak spans from its beginnings which predated 3000 BCE until significant parts of northern India fell to invaders around 900 CE. No other nation in the world has ever successfully defended itself militarily for this long.¹⁰ There has to be something about its people that makes India unique. Unfortunately, too many historians are unwilling to recognise this fact.

Even after 900 CE, while northern India kept up its spirited resistance against the invaders, southern India flourished, and in fact, continued to dominate the oceans. Southern India, via its large seaboard was the primary channel for a very large export market of textiles, spices and other goods. The empire of Vijayanagar was thriving even as the northern states came under foreign political rule all the way until the 1500s.

This was no easy achievement.

Ocean trade was disrupted when state-sanctioned European piracy that started in the sixteenth century shortly after India was 'discovered', strengthened in the seventeenth century. This had a significant impact on India's ability to control the supply chain of the products it exported. There was a large-scale trade diversion primarily by means of force in the seventeenth and the eighteenth centuries. This shifted significant profits and surplus away from India to Europe. Rapid erosion in this profitability had an ominous impact on its domestic socio-economic conditions.

This period from the 1500s to 1818 was perhaps the most dramatic transition for India than any other nation. Even as the socio-economic conditions rapidly declined, and the odds were heavily stacked against India, its people put up an incredible resistance. All the way from the North to the South and along a coastline that extends to more than 7600 kilometres, they defended every port, protected their trade and markets and, most significantly, their way of life.

Trade along the southern half of India's West Coast was protected by the Samuthiris (Anglicised as Zamorins). The Marathas, under Shivaji, defended the northern half of the West Coast. Shivaji rebuilt the navy, first, to protect its ports and second, to protect trade routes. He encouraged innovation in the ship-building industry and oversaw the building of smaller and more navigable ships to replace the much larger but sluggish cargo ships, to outrun the European pirates in the open seas. As different ports fell to the Europeans, he would reconquer them, right from Surat and all along the Konkan Coast. Shivaji did not limit himself to the West. Shivaji's last major campaign was in the South as he engaged the French near Puducherry (earlier Pondicherry).

As the Mughals crumbled in the eighteenth century, the Marathas ruled over this empire with a proxy government that paid the emperor of Delhi an annual pension of Rs. 13 lakhs (1.3 million). It controlled large

parts of India from Orissa in the East to the Indus in the West and put up a spirited resistance to defend this young empire under the leadership of Mahadji Shinde. This period of expansion of the Maratha Empire in the late eighteenth century is very relevant to the events of 1857, especially in the context of the Mughal-Maratha relations and will be discussed in detail later. After a near half century of controlling an area that was nearly the size of Ashoka's empire, the Marathas finally fell in the early nineteenth century.

The nineteenth century saw a complete loss of political and economic freedom. For the first time in India's history, the core attributes that defined India as a *nation* were also challenged in a substantive way by the policies enforced after William Bentinck's proclamation on Indian education (discussed later). In addition to plundering India's wealth and causing long-term damage to its economy, the English unleashed a systematic policy to unravel India's education system, its culture, its history, its faiths and its traditions.

This was a period of transition when the last of a major Indian resistance was defeated and English rule was taking hold. However, it was not that this transition went unchallenged. Scores of battles were fought all over India even after the fall of the Marathas in the period that spanned from 1818 to 1857. These battles continued, until something significant happened again in the 1840s. The wars in the Punjab, the second one in particular at Chillianwala (1848-9), demonstrated that the British were vulnerable. Taking a cue from Chillianwala, events were set in motion to challenge the enemy once again, but on a much larger scale.

What started in 1857 was the continuation of India's obsession to be free.

India's defeat in this War meant that India as a political unit remained under the tyranny of the English, until the events of 1946. However, Tatya's dramatic resurgence in the October of 1858 forced the English to make an important concession. They rolled back their policies to subvert India as a nation. England backed off from its attempts to destroy the core attributes that have defined India for the longest of times. As a *country*, India remained in chains, but as a *nation*, India survived.

There were many heroes who shared this obsession. An obsession to protect India's traditions, its stories, its languages, its faiths, its markets, and its economy. India has had many heroes who laid down their lives for this

freedom. This book attempts to analyse and narrate the stories of Tatya and his times, the War between the English and the Indians from 1857-9, which inspired the events of 1946 and re-established India's unique place in the world and history. This book is a tribute to the heroes of 1857 who inspired the unnamed leaders of 1946. Thanks to them, India remains today, the forever nation.

EIGHTEEN FIFTY-SEVEN AND THE TRIAD OF FREEDOM

The Indian leaders of the War of 1857 including Tatya Tope, Nana Saheb Peshwa as well as Bahadur Shah Zafar, the emperor of Delhi, under whose name the War was fought, made various proclamations during the War. One such proclamation was made by the forces that liberated Azamgarh, sixty miles north of Varanasi, by Bahadur Shah's grandson.¹¹ The proclamation was made with a specific purpose of encouraging the Indian population in this cause of freedom and seeking their support during difficult times. The following is a summary of the key points made in the five sections of the proclamation.

"The people of India are keenly aware of the tyranny and oppression of the English. I, the grandson of Bahadur Shah, have come here to declare that we will rid India of the English and will liberate the poor people who are groaning under their iron rule. I present this proclamation, to all the people of India, so that they can understand the policies that the Badshahi Government will enact. This will bring reform and freedom to the people in the following five key areas.

1. Taxation

India has been reeling from the heavy taxation the British have imposed on all the landed people of India, who in return tax the rest. I commit to lower the taxes, to preserve the dignity and honor of the people.

2. Trade and Commerce

The English government has monopolized the trade of all the fine and valuable goods that India manufactures. Products such as textiles, indigo and other articles that India has exported in the past are now a complete monopoly of the English. This leaves only the trade of trifles to the people, and even in this, they are not without their share of profits by means

of high customs, stamps, and bureaucracy that is entrenched in limiting freedom in trade.

My government will abolish these fraudulent practices and open the trade of every article, without exception, both by land and water, to all Indian merchants. The government will support this trade with steam-vessels and steam-carriages for their merchandise. Merchants with little or no capital of their own shall have access to capital at lower costs with the assistance of the government treasury as necessary.

3. Public Servants

Today, Indian officials in the British Government have a limited scope for growth – the highest level they can reach is that of a Subhedar with a salary of no more than Rs 60 or Rs 70 per month. All the Officers under my government will have starting salaries of Rs 200 to Rs 300 per month with the promise of reaching higher levels in public service. Understandably, if they cannot publicly proclaim their support to my government today – I ask them help my government indirectly and help assist us to free India from the British.

4. Industry

The British economic policies have thrown India's skilled workforce into a life of poverty. From weavers to cotton dressers, from carpenters to blacksmiths to shoemakers have all lost their livelihood under this oppressive rule of the British. Support us in this effort and help us to enjoy the fruits of our labor and economic freedom for eternal prosperity.

5. Personal Freedom

The British have imposed and forced Christianity upon us – Hindus and the Muslims alike. I urge the guardians of both faiths to join me in this effort to rid India of the British and to create a nation that freely practises its faiths and its culture'.

At the core of this proclamation was the message, that can be paraphrased as, 'help us gain *political* freedom, so you can enjoy *economic* and *personal* freedom'. This simple message is the summary of the manifesto presented by the leaders of 1857. With this, the leaders displayed an understanding of the 'triad' of freedom discussed below and the government's role in

ensuring freedom for its subjects. They specifically indicted the English for the state's interference in these areas.

European historians invented the concept of the 'Oriental Despot' from who they were 'saving the natives'. A proclamation made in 1857 demonstrates that, far from being 'despots', Indian rulers were very aware of the importance of governing principles that ensured political and personal freedom for economic prosperity.

The leaders of 1857 demonstrated that they understood the foundations of the Indian nation. A foundation that existed in the form of an implicit charter that governed organised society.

The charter that has historically existed in Indic polity for many millennia is not only the least understood of all Indian history, but also perhaps the most misunderstood. While India remains the only nation in the world, which had evolved ideas and maintained a cultural continuity for the longest of times, many ideas that allowed India to be a prosperous and free nation in the past have dramatically dimmed during the last millennium. Although these ideas were embedded in tradition, they were either lost or dismantled over a long period of foreign political rule.

The foundation of Indic polity displays a fundamental understanding of what freedom really means. Freedom in one sense comprises three mutually exclusive, but interdependent, attributes: political, economic and personal. In any organised society, these attributes correspond to some core functions that exist in society. They correspond to administrative and military functions, commercial and financial functions, and theological and philological functions respectively.

At the root of Indic polity were embedded rules that would limit the privileges of these functions. Historically, without these limits, these positions have lent themselves to abuse and misappropriation of power. While representatives in each of these three functional categories have a potential to misuse their power, the abuse gets worse when two or more of these groups connive under the pretext of collaboration. Historically in India, traditions and precedence served as a broad charter that would restrict their powers at many levels. This implicitly served as the Indic Constitution.

Western history is replete with examples of one or more of these functions grossly abusing their powers. At one point, the Roman Catholic church not only had its own army, it also connived with mercantile interests.

This represented the conglomeration of all three sources of power in the hands of a few. Protestantism emerged as a form of rejecting papal authority and doctrine.

Learning from these lessons, the founders of the United States of America, separated the powers of the church and the state in the American Constitution. While this concept was an important first step for Western civilisation, Indic thought was not only rooted in these ideals, it had additional limits on powers of the state, reflected even in the Proclamation of 1857. Not only was the Indian leadership demanding the withdrawal of religious dogma as a state policy, they specifically censured the interference of the state in economic affairs as well. In fact, three of the five sections have an emphasis on economic freedom. This message was potent and has been at the foundation of the Indian nation for the longest of times. The leaders of 1857 demonstrated a definitive understanding of Indian polity.

Despite celebrating ideals of democracy, western societies have been unable to separate economic power from the state's jurisdiction. While the Constitution of the United States set out to limit the power of the government, the creation of the Federal Reserve in 1913 went against the spirit of the US Constitution.¹² Many other nations followed and all powerful central banks became the central authority in defining monetary policies. In continuation of their mercantile history, trade and monetary policies today remain to be the cornerstone of political power in the West. Although these principles are in complete contradiction to India's long history, 'modern' India embraced these principles, under the pretext of a 'benevolent' government.

Of the three primary goals of the War of 1857 as presented in the manifesto of 25 August 1857, Tatya Tope achieved one monumental goal on 1 November 1858. As a later chapter discusses, India succeeded in taking one important step towards freedom. The next step was taken on 18 February 1946. However, in view of the triad of freedom, Tatya's task remains unfinished. The book later discusses some important additional steps India must take to achieve complete freedom in this context.

Understanding 1857 is critical for India to build on its current system, to allow its people to live their lives freely and enjoy the fruits of their labour; to create a government that, neither abuses its powers, nor interferes in economic and personal freedom of its subjects.

Only with this understanding can India truly celebrate its unbroken streak as the world's only ancient living civilisation, and the world's only Forever Nation.